EDITOR'S DESK · 03

Ten times.

The average number of times a winner of the AMJ Best Article Award rewrote the introduction to the paper that won.

Grant and Pollock asked 22 of them.

WHAT THEY FOUND

The introduction is under 10% of the paper. It takes a quarter of the writing time.

1 24%, share of total writing time award winners spent on the introduction

2 86%, rewrote it more times than any other part of the paper

3 45%, rewrote it ten times or more; the minimum reported was three

4 3 pages, the modal recommendation for its length, double-spaced

An effective introduction answers three sets of questions

1 WHO CARES? What is the question, and why does it matter in theory and in practice?

2 WHAT DO WE KNOW, WHAT DON'T WE, AND SO WHAT? Which conversation are you joining, where has it not gone, and why should it go there?

3 WHAT WILL WE LEARN? How does this change, challenge or advance what scholars understand?

THE VOCABULARY

How editors talk about introductions

Setting the hook

The opening device that makes a reader continue. Grant and Pollock find two archetypes in award-winning papers: the provocative quotation, and the trend.

Establishing the field

Locke and Golden-Biddle's term for showing which conversation you are joining, by bridging two, advancing one, or resolving competing ones.

Problematizing the field

Showing why that conversation must move: it is incomplete, inadequate, or altogether inaccurate. Three different strengths of claim.

Consensus shifting / creation

Hollenbeck's pair. Shifting: challenge an assumption readers hold. Creation: show the literature lacks agreement, then resolve it.

Pasteur's quadrant

Stokes's term for research that advances basic understanding and applied use at once. Where an effective introduction plants its roots.

Two ways to frame a contribution

CONSENSUS SHIFTING

Identify a widely held assumption. Challenge it. Describe what follows for ongoing research.

The reader believed something when they started your introduction and does not believe it by the end.

CONSENSUS CREATION

Show that the literature lacks consensus. Then either clarify the lines of debate or resolve the conflict.

The reader saw a mess when they started and sees an order by the end.

WHAT REVIEWERS SEE GO WRONG

Three failure modes, in order of frequency

1 60%, failing to motivate the paper and problematise the literature. “Bad frames, like ‘This has never been done before’ and ‘This fills in a gap.’”

2 45%, lacking focus. Cramming in what the study covers “at the expense of being compelling, intriguing, interesting.”

3 14%, overpromising. Setting expectations in the introduction the rest of the paper does not meet.

“

Not all gaps need to be filled!

An AMJ Outstanding Reviewer, quoted in Grant & Pollock (2011), and the sentence this whole series turns on

SOURCES

Grant, A. M., & Pollock, T. G. (2011). Publishing in AMJ, Part 3: Setting the hook. Academy of Management Journal, 54(5), 873–879.

Hollenbeck, J. R. (2008). The role of editing in knowledge development: Consensus shifting and consensus creation. In Opening the black box of editorship (pp. 16–26). Palgrave Macmillan.

Locke, K., & Golden-Biddle, K. (1997). Constructing opportunities for contribution. Academy of Management Journal, 40(5), 1023–1062.

An honest limit: this is self-report from award winners at one journal, recalled years later. It shows you what success looks like from the inside. It does not show that rewriting ten times causes an award.

THE QUESTION

How many times have you rewritten the introduction to the paper you are working on now?

And when did you write it, at the start, or after you knew what you had found?

Saturday: Whetten on what has to be true of the work underneath those three pages.

Tell me in the comments